

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

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FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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Published by Faithful Path Community,
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CHAPTER 15

Building a Sustainable Rule of Life

For the second and third weeks home

By now you have kept one rhythm for a week or two, imperfectly, and done a few of the cards. This chapter is about turning that one rhythm into a small pattern that can carry you: what older Christian traditions call a rule of life. It takes two or three weeks to build well, and it should be built in ordinary life, not on retreat, because ordinary life is where it has to work.

What a rule of life is, and is not

The word "rule" puts some people off, and it should be explained. It comes from the Latin *regula*, meaning a rule or straightedge, a guide by which something is given shape. A helpful modern image is a trellis: a structure along which a living thing can grow without being crushed. A rule of life, in that sense, is not a set of laws. It is a small, chosen pattern of prayer, rest, work, and relationship that gives your life a shape it will not find by drifting.

Christians have made such patterns for a very long time. Benedict's sixth-century Rule is the best-known example. It sought an ordered life of prayer, work, reading, community, and rest, while stating that nothing unnecessarily "harsh or burdensome" should be imposed. But the idea is older than Benedict and much simpler than a monastery. **Daniel 6:10**

records that Daniel prayed three times a day, at his window, "as he had done previously," and that fixed pattern was what his enemies used against him, because it was so reliable. The early church, in **Acts 2:42**, "devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers," which is a rule of life in one sentence: teaching, community, table, prayer.

A rule is not legalism. **Galatians 5:1** says, "For freedom Christ has set us free; stand firm therefore, and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery." A rule that becomes a way of earning God's approval, or a measuring stick you beat yourself with, has stopped being a trellis and become a cage, and it should be torn up. Chapter 2 said that rest is a declaration that God, not you, holds the world together. A rule of life is the same declaration, made weekly.

For many burned-out people, however, the more immediate danger is drift. Without a chosen pattern, the loudest demand wins every day, and prayer, rest, and the people you love are what get squeezed. A rule is how you decide in advance what will not be squeezed. It is not a burden added to a full life. It is a fence around the parts of life that were being trampled.

Sabbath: regular ceasing at the centre of the rule

Session Ten promised that Part Five would give Sabbath the fuller treatment it deserves. Here it is, because this guide strongly recommends a regular period of worship, ceasing, rest, and delight as the centre of any sustainable Christian rhythm.

Where it comes from. Chapter 2 traced it: God rests on the seventh day in **Genesis 2:2–3**, not from tiredness but to establish a pattern for the people made in his image. In **Exodus 20:8–11**, the Sabbath command is grounded in creation: rest because God

rested. In **Deuteronomy 5:12–15**, the same command is grounded in liberation: rest because you were slaves in Egypt and are no longer. Both reasons still hold. Sabbath declares that the world was made and is held by God, and it declares that you are not a slave to your work, your phone, or anyone's expectations.

What Jesus did with it. By Jesus' time the Sabbath had accumulated rules that made it a burden, and much of his conflict with religious leaders was over this. In **Mark 2:23–28**, when his disciples are criticised for plucking grain on the Sabbath, he says, "The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath." He healed on the Sabbath repeatedly and defended it: "Is it lawful on the Sabbath to do good or to do harm, to save life or to kill?" (Mark 3:4). Jesus rejected Sabbath interpretations that undermined mercy and human flourishing. Christians differ over whether his teaching continues, fulfils, or transforms the command, but all can see in it God's concern for worship, mercy, freedom, and human limits.

What Christians have made of it. Some keep a strict seventh-day observance. Many have transferred the principle to Sunday, the day of resurrection. Paul, in **Colossians 2:16–17** and **Romans 14:5–6**, refused to let the observance of days become a matter of judgement between believers. **Hebrews 4:9–11** speaks of a Sabbath rest that remains for God's people and places the deepest meaning of rest within God's saving work; Christians differ over what this means for weekly observance. This guide does not require agreement about a particular day, and you may follow your own conviction and your church's teaching. What it does strongly recommend is the principle beneath the debate: God built a rhythm of ceasing into creation and into his people's freedom, and a life without it is not the life you were made for.

How to practise it. Choose a period, ideally a full day, and if that is impossible, a half-day or an evening- to-evening, in which you

stop your ordinary work. Not only paid work: the work of managing, fixing, improving, and producing. Then fill the time with what Sabbath is for: worship, if the day allows it; rest, including sleep; delight, meaning the things that restore you and that you never have time for; and people, unhurried. Keep the phone boundary from Chapter 9. Do not use the day to catch up.

Sabbath is not neglect. Necessary care, acts of mercy, emergencies, and responsibilities that genuinely cannot be postponed may remain; Jesus' Sabbath healings settle that. The aim is to cease avoidable production and management, not to become unavailable to human need.

Three practical problems, and their answers. **If Sunday is your work day**, as it is for pastors, church staff, and many shift workers, take another day, and protect it as fiercely as a pastor's Sunday is protected for everyone else. Program 7 said this; Sabbath on Monday is still Sabbath. **If you are a caregiver** and cannot stop caring for a day, then if safe respite is available, receiving it is not selfish. If it is not available, look for what might be called Sabbath fragments: a protected hour, help with one task, prayer while another person sits with the one you care for. Receive those limits without guilt. **If a full day is impossible now**, start with what is possible, a protected half-day, and let it grow. A half-day kept for a year is worth more than a full day intended and never taken.

What it costs, and what it says. Sabbath will cost you something, at first: the things that do not get done, the sense that you are falling behind, the discomfort of stopping. That cost is the point. Each time you stop, you practise the truth that your responsibility has limits and that God remains God while you rest. The week may not unfold perfectly, but your limits remain real, and God's faithfulness does not depend on your uninterrupted work. The manna in Exodus 16 did not fall on the

seventh day, and the people who trusted that had enough. That is the lesson, weekly.

The other parts of the rule

Around the Sabbath, a rule of life covers a few other areas. The rule as a whole should fit on one page, and three to five commitments in total is enough. Begin with the three core areas. Add the others only if they help.

Core: regular ceasing and rest. The Sabbath practice above, and sleep. Chapter 11 said sleep is a gift; protect a realistic sleep window where possible, follow any medical care you need, and avoid sacrificing sleep merely to complete devotional practices.

Core: prayer and Scripture. A fixed time, however short, most days, with a simple reading plan that does not depend on feeling like it. The Chapter 8 practice, a psalm and a few minutes of silence, is a complete daily pattern for a tired person. Grow it later if you want to. The fixed time matters more than the length; Daniel's window was about the fixedness.

Core: one limit that protects your health or calling. Usually a work limit. Ministers and the self-employed especially need this: a number of hours, an evening that is off, a day that is not touched. The Jethro conversation in Chapter 14 may have produced it. Write it into the rule so that it is a decision made once rather than fifty times a week.

Optional: a relationship you will tend. Church, first: a community you belong to and are known in, not only one you serve. If you are between churches or recovering from church harm, name one safe form of Christian connection you can sustain while you seek a healthy community. Then the people the retreat identified: your Eli, your support person, the friend you see monthly, the spouse you protect an evening for.

Optional: body. From Chapter 11: how you will eat, move, and look after your health in the ordinary week. Keep it simple and medical where it needs to be medical.

Optional: screens. The element of Chapter 9 you chose to keep. Name it exactly, so that it is a rule and not a wish.

Writing it

Take one page. Copy this template and fill in the core lines. Leave the optional lines blank unless one of them is where the retreat pointed.

My rule for this season Date: _____ Regular ceasing and rest: Prayer and Scripture: One limit that protects my health or calling: One relationship I will tend (optional): Additional commitment (optional): When I miss something: I will resume at the next appropriate opportunity without punishment, compensation, or guilt.
Two-week check: _____ Three-month review: _____ Person I will share this with: _____

Here is an example, deliberately unimpressive, because unimpressive rules are the ones that get kept:

*Regular ceasing and rest: Saturday noon to evening; no paid work or email; eat with family and walk.
 Phone stays outside the bedroom.
 Prayer and Scripture: a psalm and five minutes of prayer at 7:00 a.m., Monday to Friday.
 One limit: laptop closed by 7:00 p.m.
 When I miss something: I will resume at the next appropriate opportunity without punishment, compensation, or guilt.*

Two-week check: 14 March.

Three-month review: 30 June.

Sharing with: Paul.

"Without compensation" matters. Some readers will try to repay a missed Sabbath with a double one, or a missed morning with an hour of penitential prayer. Do not. Resume.

Read the page to God. Then share the page, or the commitments on which you want accountability, with your Eli or support person, and ask them to ask you about it at the review dates. You remain responsible for deciding what personal details they need to see. A rule that nobody else knows about is easy to abandon quietly.

Two cautions. Do not write the rule you wish you had the capacity for. Write the one you can keep in a difficult ordinary week, and let it grow at the reviews. And do not write it alone if you share a life; a Sabbath that your spouse or household does not know about will collide with theirs. Program 5's third shared moment was for exactly this.

Reviewing it

At two weeks, a light check: is this livable? If the rule already feels like a cage, remove something immediately. You do not need to wait for the formal review date to subtract.

At three months, sit down with the page and your Eli and ask four questions. What have I kept? What have I dropped, and why? What has changed in my life that the rule needs to reflect? What one thing would I add or remove? Then rewrite the page with the new date. A rule of life is not written once. It is revised for the rest of your life, and every revision is a small act of the same trust that Sabbath is: that God holds the world, and that you can afford to stop and look at how you are living in it.

Before Chapter 16

1. What day or period will be your regular ceasing, and what is the first thing you will have to stop doing to protect it?
2. Which core commitments will you write this quarter? Will you add any optional line, or leave them blank?
3. Who will you share the page with, and when are the two-week check and the three-month review?
4. Is there anything in the rule you have written that is already a cage rather than a trellis? Cross it out.